Who Is the Dalai Lama?

February 22, 1940, was a busy day at the Potala, a grand, thousand-room palace high in the mountains of Tibet. Early in the morning, guests started to fill the main assembly hall. They were waiting for their leader to arrive.

Once the hall was full, the crowd grew quiet. A little boy, dressed in golden robes, entered. Horn and trumpet blasts greeted him. He crossed the room on a white carpet that had been rolled out especially for him to a jeweled throne. It was called the Lion Throne because of the eight lions carved into the wooden base of the tall, cushioned chair. The throne was the seat of the Dalai Lama (say: DAHL-eye LAH-muh), a name given to the political and religious leader of the country of Tibet.

The young Dalai Lama needed some help climbing up the steps to his throne. He sat cross-legged on the seat and watched the ceremonies, dances, and readings. Many gifts were set out for the boy—a music box, the tusk of an elephant, expensive fabrics, parakeets, a tricycle, and even a brick of gold! Holy men, government officials, and the others in attendance, in a sign of respect, bowed so low before him that they were lying on the floor. “I found that funny,” he later said. The Dalai Lama is known for his sense of humor. But it was especially funny to him that the adults were acting this way. After all, he was only four years old!

As he grew, that young boy on the Lion Throne began to understand why that day was so special. As Tibet’s Fourteenth Dalai Lama, he would face joyful times and difficult times. He would grow in wisdom. And he would become caring and strong.